credibility. He worked hard and made tough calls. If he wanted to run for political office, I think he would have won, hands down. Pakistanis love a good leader, be it in or out of uniform.

Towards the end of his military career, there were rumours about him staying on and getting an extension. Obviously, a public issue doesn't get more controversial than a military chief staying on in power in Pakistan. We are, after all, the land of military coups.

However, my take on the matter in 2016 wasn't something mainstream. I was of the opinion that the army must wrap up the war against terror which has been so hard-fought during these past few years, and bring it to its logical conclusion. It must finish terrorism, once and for all. If Raheel Sharif started the war, then Raheel Sharif should end it. That's what I first thought. But because his staying on would create political controversy, I was willing to shift my positioning too, based on his successor.

If the military felt that Raheel Sharif's successor was good enough to handle the war against terror as well as the mighty Pakistan army, then Sharif sahib should go ahead and retire. But if there was even an inkling of doubt about his successor, or the administration that would follow him, then Raheel Sharif must stay. That's what I'd thought when the future of the country and the army was being discussed. But thank God, General Qamar Javed Bajwa, whom I haven't met properly till date, is an able successor to lead the Pakistan army. That's because the army has a system. It's the only organization in Pakistan that has a method and sticks to it.

Back to General Raheel Sharif: meeting him was like meeting a family elder. He wanted to know about the state of Pakistan cricket, why we were not building enough cricket academies. He was hungry for information, concerned even.

Another army chief who showed the same concern for the game was General Pervez Musharraf. Sure, everybody knows that he was a big fan of cricket but I felt he was a bigger student of understanding the dynamics of improving local cricket so that it could play a role in improving Pakistan's international cricket standing. I appreciated his interest. It was a part of his statesmanship.

Unfortunately, when I met another so-called leader, I didn't get the same response. It was after one of our championship victories, when we were invited to Islamabad to meet President Asif Ali Zardari. Zardari sahib just showed up, brusquely shook our hands, smiled for the photo-op and left. He wasn't interested in our victory, in the game of cricket or in improving sports for Pakistanis. He was just counting the seconds for the photographers to do their job and leave. I was really disappointed. In fact, I remember feeling a bit angry too.

Sure, Zardari is a heck of a politician. His temperament is amazing. He survived five years in office and almost a decade in jail, a time when most people and institutions wanted his head on a stick. In a place like Pakistan, a full term in office is no small feat. Zardari is a survivor. But he isn't a cricket fan, nor is he a great leader. That's something I hold against him.

By the way, here's a little inside scoop: Qamar Javed Bajwa, the chief of army staff, does better cricket analysis than most commentators and analysts. Ramiz Raja and Harsha Bhogle, you better watch out.